

Google meets Turnberry

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CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you ... and so much for yesterday's last-day-of-school mood . Turns out the Commission spokesperson who earlier this week said "the EU never goes on vacation" was right.

In today's Playbook:

— A Bulgarian homecoming to test the waters on Ukraine.

— The EPP faces pushback over its handling of the far-right's EU funds scandal.

— Faces in the crowd: Roberta Metsola, Ilaria Salis, Michael O'Flaherty, Donald Trump, Ekaterina Zaharieva, Kathleen Van Brempt, Frank Vandenbroucke, Rumen Radev, Bryant Trick, Iliana Yotova, Ditte Juul Jørgensen, Ursula von der Leyen, Bart De Wever, Mykhailo Fedorov and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Kathryn explain why the expected record Google fine could land the EU in another transatlantic trade war.

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DRIVING THE DAY

THE PERFECT STORM: Buckle up. The next 48 hours could make for one of the trickiest transatlantic balancing acts in months, with the European Commission preparing to slap Google with a landmark fine just as U.S. President Donald Trump has to decide what to do with expiring tariffs on trade with the EU.

Playing with fire? The Commission is expected — as early as today or tomorrow — to fine the U.S. tech giant for breaching the Digital Markets Act, the EU's rulebook to stop very big online platforms from

abusing their power.

What did Google do? The search giant is accused of illegally favoring its own services over those of competitors via its search engine, with a second penalty over Google Play also in the pipeline. The probe started in March 2024 and a decision was ready in March this year, POLITICO reported at the time. But Brussels held off to give the company one last chance to comply.

How we know it's coming: The Digital Markets Advisory Committee — the group of national experts the Commission must consult before signing off on DMA decisions — meets today, my colleagues Jacob Parry and Francesca Micheletti report. This has raised expectations that the decision will be published shortly after.

Normally ... this would be simply another pre-holiday DG COMP special. The Commission's competition department likes clearing the decks before everyone disappears to the beach and Brussels has been signaling since May that Google would be next.

Except this isn't an ordinary week. Washington is racing to rebuild its tariffs after earlier legal setbacks, with Trump's temporary "global" 10 percent tariffs on almost all U.S. imports — unless specifically exempted — expiring tomorrow. The U.S. administration is expected to unveil a replacement before then and the EU is anxiously waiting to see whether Washington sticks to the Turnberry understanding — the political accord between the EU and the U.S. that caps tariffs on almost all EU goods at 15 percent.

Eggshell diplomacy: DG Trade chief Ditte Juul Jørgensen sought to reassure ambassadors yesterday. She said the Commission still expects the U.S. to respect the deal, but if it didn't, the EU executive would be ready to come up with countermeasures, three EU diplomats familiar with the discussion told POLITICO's Camille Gijs. One of them added that envoys would be ready to convene an extraordinary EU ambassadors' meeting next week if the U.S. springs a surprise.

Pressure from both sides: In Washington, Republicans have written to the White House, asking the administration to push back against the DMA. In Brussels, the pressure points the other way: More than 40 European companies wrote to Commission President Ursula von der Leyen over the weekend, urging the Commission to stop waiting and enforce the rules against Google.

Across the Atlantic: A delegation of MEPs from the Socialists and Democrats is spending the week in Washington and meets Assistant U.S. Trade Representative Bryant Trick this afternoon. "It is a particularly relevant moment to be in Washington, given the renewed tariff announcements," MEP Kathleen Van Brempt told Camille. "Our message will be straightforward: Europe wants Turnberry to work, but that requires both sides to respect the commitments they made."

Bottom line: For the next 48 hours, Brussels' mood could be summed up by one sentence: Hope for Turnberry; prepare for turbulence.

BIG AND BREAKING

TRUMP'S WARNING: Iran keeps targeting commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, Donald Trump says, and the U.S. could respond by striking bridges and power plants ... while Iran-backed Houthis say they targeted two oil tankers in the Red Sea ... and all this as only about a third of Trump voters now think the conflict with Iran is worth the economic cost.

LOOKING AT YOU, GREECE: EU ambassadors take another crack at the Russia sanctions package today after Greece again sank a deal over measures affecting its gas shipping industry.

MACRON'S CHARM OFFENSIVE: French Ecological Transition Minister Monique Barbut has withdrawn her resignation , after President Emmanuel Macron asked her to stay.

SALIS LOSES IN COURT: Italian MEP Ilaria Salis has been ordered by an Italian court to pay compensation over the dismissal of two assistants, according to Italian media . Salis described the ruling as “bordering on the surreal” and announced an appeal.

RUSSIAN FUEL, GERMAN GREEN LIGHT: A nuclear project linked to Russian state-owned company Rosatom has been given the go-ahead by state authorities in northwest Germany, under strict conditions. POLITICO first reported the project.

FUELING NATO: Atlantic allies have sealed a €27 billion deal to drag NATO's military-fuel transport network out of the Cold War era.

DOWN UNDER DRONES: Germany wants combat drones by 2029, but a fight over whether to buy Australian or wait for European models risks delaying the plan .

RAMPANT AI: OpenAI's admission that one of its powerful artificial intelligence models escaped a controlled laboratory test has U.S. lawmakers hurrying to advance legislation .

ENGAGING SOFIA ON UKRAINE

RELATIONSHIP RESET? Bulgarian Innovation Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva is heading home today to take the temperature on Ukraine. She will sound out whether Sofia is on the same page as Brussels on how to counter Russia. She'll also get a sense of whether the new government is finally ready to push through the reforms needed to unlock the country's frozen Recovery and Resilience Facility money.

Tough times: The visit comes after a bumpy few weeks. The EU has been trying to decipher Bulgaria's line since Prime Minister Rumen Radev's July 14 announcement that the country would leave the Coalition of the Willing — the group of countries coordinating military and financial support for Kyiv.

Why the confusion? Because just a day after Radev's announcement, Bulgarian Foreign Minister Velislava Petrova traveled to Kyiv for the Ukraine–Southeast Europe Summit and endorsed a joint declaration — something Brussels read as broadly in line with the coalition's objectives.

It's on the table: Don't expect Ukraine to go unmentioned just because it isn't on the official agenda, an EU official told Playbook. “I expect it will come up ... especially since [Zaharieva] used to be a foreign minister.”

Read the guest list: On paper, Zaharieva is making a routine courtesy trip on the new government on behalf of the Commission. Her schedule tells a more complicated story: The commissioner for startups and innovation is meeting PM Radev and President Iliana Yotova — not the cast you'd expect for a discussion about EU research funds.

Don't forget the money: More than €2.7 billion in grants after the pandemic in Bulgaria's Recovery Fund — the EU instruments to mitigate pandemic's impact — remain partially frozen over targets that haven't

been met, notably on rule-of-law and anti-corruption reforms. The Commission also wants to know — two months after the newly elected Radev visited Brussels — whether the new government is ready to get the reform job done and unblock the file.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

There are such deep divisions over a controversial child abuse scanning bill that it could end up in an EU conciliation procedure — a mechanism used earlier this year to pass a long-stalled law on air passengers' rights. But what is it? The procedure is the third and final stage of discussions on a new bill — if it fails, the legislation is rejected. To try to break the deadlock, a Conciliation Committee is set up featuring representatives of member countries and Parliament, with the Commission as a mediator. Once it's established, the committee has six weeks to agree on a joint text, which will then go back to Council and Parliament for approval.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked listeners to write in with their end of year exam stories. Whatsapp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

PARLIAMENT MISSPENDING CONTROVERSY

EPP LAMBASTED OVER PATRIOTS REPORT: Four political groups — Renew Europe, S&D, the Greens and The Left — have lashed out at the European People's Party. They're unhappy with the center-right group's vote with the far-right Patriots for Europe on a report into the latter's misuse of EU funds, and they say the report has been watered down.

To the top: In a letter to European Parliament President Roberta Metsola, the four groups ask the EPP MEP to seek a legal opinion on whether last week's vote in the Parliament's budgetary control committee breached the institution's conflict-of-interest rules.

Recap: Parliament officials found the Patriots broke EU rules on donations and procurement worth €270,000 in 2024 and €546,000 in 2025 .

In the committee, the EPP sided with the Patriots, backing what the center and left-wing parties say was a less-damning text that merely acknowledged the irregularities and requested repayment. On the same type of misspending by the now-defunct far-right Identity and Democracy group, the committee in 2025 issued a detailed report urging the administration to take tough action.

The four also ask whether the Parliament had referred the two instances of misspending to the EU public prosecutor and anti-fraud office: "Neither the assessment nor the accompanying correspondence indicates that such reports, or an assessment of the need for one, have been made." They also ask whether the Parliament has opened an administrative inquiry into the Patriots official who signed off the irregular expenditure.

8 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

BOOSTING THE BERLAYMONT BUNKER: The Commission's Secretariat-General is growing. From September, it will host a new office coordinating the Security College — the commissioners' defense and security unit.

KYIV'S BLAME GAME: Allies of Volodymyr Zelenskyy are increasingly pinning responsibility for the political fallout from the firing of Defense Minister Mykhailo Fedorov on Fedorov himself. More in Morning Defense (for subscribers).

BURNHAM TRADE INSIGHT: Andy Burnham's intervention in a U.S.-U.K. trade dialogue in 2022 offers one of the most revealing insights yet into the new prime minister's thinking on trade.

HOLD BEFORE A HIKE? The European Central Bank is expected to leave interest rates unchanged today. More in Morning Financial Services (for subscribers).

MACRON'S DIGITAL LEGACY: France has approved a ban on social media for under-15s , handing the president one of his biggest second-term tech victories.

HUAWEI PRICE TAG: Kicking Huawei and other high-risk vendors out of Europe's telecoms networks could cost up to four times more than Brussels' own estimates, the industry says .

CHILD-POVERTY WARNING: Council of Europe Human Rights Commissioner Michael O'Flaherty publishes a memorandum today urging Italy to put child poverty at the center of public spending, with one in seven children living in absolute poverty.

PHARMA CARVE-OUT? Brussels expects generic medicines to dodge Trump's latest tariffs , arguing Washington committed to zero duties in last year's transatlantic deal.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Overcast, high of 22C.

SUMMER FUNFAIR: Brussels' largest fair is open for business. The Foire du Midi kicked off last weekend with more than 100 attractions along a 1.6-kilometer stretch between Porte de Hal and Brussels-Midi railway station, and will continue for five weeks. The fair is considered "intangible cultural heritage " of Brussels and can draw a million visitors.

RYANAIR VS. BELGIUM: Low-coast carrier Ryanair is pulling five planes from its base at Brussels South Charleroi Airport. The airline announced the decision Wednesday , citing government plans to increase a passenger tax on flights of more than 500 kilometers from €5 to €7 per ticket. "We warned Prime Minister [Bart] De Wever that increasing Belgium's aviation tax would result in traffic cuts, but he failed to listen," Ryanair CEO Eddie Wilson said.

Compromise offer: The announcement follows a back-and-forth between Belgian policymakers and the airline, which prompted the Belgian government to soften initial plans to increase the tax to €10. Health Minister Frank Vandenbroucke said the €7 passenger tax had been offered in response to Ryanair's pressure.

COLOR ME BAD: I may have a reputation around town for being colorblind, but that doesn't excuse yesterday's Playbook for mixing up its parliamentary colors. As many of you pointed out, this week is, of course, a green week, with MEPs out on work trips and in their constituencies, just as today's Driving the Day shows. My apologies.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The dance within the CDU/CSU alliance over personnel placements as part of the government reshuffle has only just begun .

London: Andy Burnham keeps his summer-of-savings policy blitz rolling this morning, with a barnstorming tour that will take him from Essex to Scotland.

Paris: Sébastien Lecornu has jumped through an obligatory hoop for anyone wanting to run for president: an interview with Paris Match .

Washington PM: House Republicans and Democrats are facing a reckoning on the war in Iran, as Trump ramps up the military threats .

AGENDA

- ECB monetary policy meeting in Frankfurt. Press conference at 2:45 p.m. Watch .
- High Representative Kaja Kallas attends the ASEAN Regional Forum in Manila and meets the foreign ministers of Australia, Bangladesh, Egypt, Laos, Singapore and South Korea.
- Research Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva meets Bulgarian Prime Minister Rumen Radev and President Iliana Yotova in Sofia.
- EU Defense Night in Washington, D.C., with Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius delivering a speech. On the sidelines, the commissioner meets U.S. Senator Roger Wicker.
- Love Tomorrow Summit at the sidelines of the Tomorrowland Festival in Boom, Belgium, with Youth Commissioner Glenn Micallef giving a speech.
- Informal meeting of environment and climate ministers in Dublin.

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEPs Thierry Cornillet and Arne Lietz; Saulius Skvernelis, former PM of Lithuania; The Economist's Lane Greene; Belgian Navy Staff Officer Michel Buekens; Italian President Sergio Mattarella.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editor James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Google:** We want to see a higher industry standard for safer features, content and settings. That's why we've spent a decade building tailored products and protections for youth. Google Family Link and new expanded Android parental controls provide tools that respect families' individual choices with technology, helping them create healthy, positive digital habits. With easy-to-use tools, you can understand how your child is spending time on their device, share location, manage privacy settings, and find the right balance for your family. All part of our mission to protect kids in the digital world, not from it. ******

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